

FREE RESOURCE

Referral Triage Decision Card

A teacher just sent you a referral. Now what?

 Step 1 · Assess Urgency

 Step 2 · Check Flags

 Step 3 · Choose Your Response

 Step 4 · Document

STEP 1 — ASSESS URGENCY

Every referral lands in exactly one lane

● SEE TODAY

- Suicidal statements or self-harm
- Abuse/neglect disclosure
- Active crisis (panic attack, uncontrollable crying)
- Threat to harm others
- Student not picked up / abandoned

→ **Pull the student immediately. Follow crisis protocol.**

● SEE THIS WEEK

- Sudden behavior change
- Frequent tearfulness
- Social isolation (new pattern)
- Declining grades (rapid drop)
- Bullying report
- Parent request for counseling

→ **Schedule within 48 hours. Observe in classroom first if possible.**

● SCHEDULE WHEN READY

- Social skills concern
- Mild anxiety (test worry, new situations)
- Friendship difficulty
- New student adjustment
- Academic planning
- Self-referral for "someone to talk to"

→ **Add to caseload. Schedule within 1–2 weeks. Consider group placement.**

STEP 2 — CHECK FLAGS · STEP 4 — DOCUMENT

Before the first session · After every referral

BEFORE YOUR FIRST SESSION, CHECK:

- ☐ **Is this student SPED?** → Coordinate with the SPED teacher. Document in IEP notes.
- ☐ **Is this student 504?** → Review accommodations. May need a plan update.
- ☐ **Is this student on a BIP?** → Read the plan. Your sessions should align.
- ☐ **Has this student been referred before?** → Pull prior notes. Look for patterns.
- ☐ **Is there a custody issue?** → Check who has pick-up rights. Be careful with parent contact.
- ☐ **Is there a language barrier?** → Arrange an interpreter if needed.

EVERY REFERRAL GETS:

- Date received, source (teacher / parent / self / admin)
- Concern type and urgency level
- Action taken and date of first contact
- Parent notification (date, method, response)
- Follow-up plan

⚠️ "If you didn't document it, it didn't happen."

STEP 3 — CHOOSE YOUR RESPONSE

Match the concern to a first response, persistence plan, and escalation path

Concern Type	First Response	If Persists (4+ weeks)	Escalation
Academic	Teacher consultation + classroom observation	Individual counseling + parent conference	RTI/MTSS referral
Behavioral	Behavior check-in (2 weeks)	Individual counseling + behavior plan	FBA referral + admin involvement
Social-Emotional	Individual session + group placement	Weekly individual + coping skills group	Outside counselor referral
Family Situation	Individual session + parent outreach	Ongoing support + community resources	DFPS report if safety concern (24-hr duty, TFC \$261.101)
Attendance	Parent phone call + check-in	Attendance contract + home visit team	Truancy officer referral
Crisis	Immediate intervention (see Step 1)	Safety plan + outside referral	911 / DFPS / hospitalization